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Bill would ease applying for affordable homes

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Three months into her search for a new apartment closer to family in the South Bay, Judy Jackson is feeling a familiar sense of dread.

At age 76, it's not just the packing that's daunting for the Berkeley resident and two-time cancer survivor. It's that the last time she was looking for an affordable place with a county housing voucher, she ended up in a shelter while she waited for her name to be called for a new home.

"I was homeless for five months," Jackson recalled. "I signed up on a wait list in October, and it didn't come up until March."

Jackson's last housing search was years ago, around 2001, but multiple tech booms since haven't changed the old-school process of applying for many affordable homes in California, which still require prospective residents to sign up in person or by mail. So now, she's part of a group of tenants backing a state bill, AB 1961, to create a new online application system and first-of-its-kind state database of affordable apartment listings.

A few Bay Area locales already have similar systems, including San Francisco's 4-year-old Dahlia housing portal. Supporters say that the state proposal, estimated to cost around $20 million, is a commonsense way to cut application time and money for renters already struggling to get by.

One thing technology can't fix: California's real-life lack of affordable homes.

Tens of thousands of people are already on Bay Area wait lists for federally funded housing vouchers that cap rent at 30% of income, with the government paying the rest up to set amounts. Popularly known as Section 8, the vouchers are seen as a key strategy to triage the housing crisis as prices soar. But in nearby counties like Contra Costa, which this week reported a 35% three-year jump in homelessness, officials say only 40% of people given emergency vouchers during the pandemic have found a home to accept them.

"When people are applying for affordable housing, they are often on the brink of homelessness," said Tori Truscheit, organizing director for advocacy group Housing California. "What this bill does is remind people who might not have gone through this that the process of applying for housing is a beast."

Like Jackson, Oakland resident Willie Stevens, 73, first learned how hard it was to find an affordable Bay Area home when he was facing a time crunch to find one.

Stevens, a Bay Area transplant who left Ohio after the auto bust in the 1980s, retired from his 25-year career as an apartment manager in 2011. After his Social Security income started arriving, he realized the $872-a-month checks left him with virtually nothing after paying his $850-a-month uptown Oakland rent. By 2014, he'd fallen behind on rent, gone to court and said he was given one month to leave.

So began a year-and-a-half-long odyssey of applying for dozens of affordable homes with a county housing voucher.

At first, Stevens put his things in storage, stayed in hotels, searched for apartments on library computers, then drove to buildings to fill out applications. But as his $25,000 in retirement savings dwindled, Stevens said he sold the car and switched to the bus. At the end of the long wait before he got to the top of the list for an East Oakland

senior housing complex in January 2016, he prayed each night on a friend's couch.

"It got really hard," Stevens said. "I would have to eat, and I was trying to pay my credit cards off, because I knew they would check my credit."

Jackson's and Stevens' own experiences with Bay Area housing bureaucracy pushed them to become activists. It was last September when they and fellow members of a Housing California-backed group for affordable housing tenants, called Residents United Network, or RUN, came together for a brainstorming session informally called "There oughta be a law."

Other residents voiced familiar frustrations about money blown on bus fare to would-be homes, only to find out applications were closed. Or having to constantly update addresses and resend the same financial information and personal documents while living in a car, couch-surfing or bouncing between shelters.

"What I had to go through, I find it's pretty typical," Stevens said. His hope now is "for nobody else to have to go through the same type of thing."

By early this year, Truscheit said, the idea that became AB1961 attracted a state lawmaker to back it, Assembly Member Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino (Los Angeles County). East Bay representative Buffy Wicks and the South Bay's Evan Low signed on as co-authors of the bill, which is set to be considered by a state appropriations committee as soon as Thursday.

As currently written, the measure would task the state Department of Housing and Community Development with creating a central online system where tenants can store application materials, opt to receive email alerts about new housing openings and get updates on their application status. Potential homes listed in the database would include deed-restricted, multiunit affordable housing, properties that usually receive public construction funds in exchange for fixing rental rates at no more than 30% of income. It's a pool that includes 504,872 homes statewide, according to a California Housing Partnership Corporation estimate cited in an analysis of the bill.

"As a little fix for this gigantic housing crisis," Truscheit said, "I think it's absolutely possible."

The challenge is that similar local systems, like Alameda County's, currently show just one active rental listing for veterans. San Francisco's site, which was also built by housing tech contractor Exygy, lists one building accepting applications, two upcoming lotteries and additional options for seniors, people with disabilities or renters open to moving out of state.

As Jackson has seen in her own search of the Bay Area's chaotic pandemic housing market, there are other options that likely wouldn't be captured in the database, like private landlords who express a willingness to accept vouchers on Craigslist. A separate Wicks bill, AB2469, would create a broader statewide rental registry to more systematically track rents, evictions and other factors affecting tenants and landlords.

While negotiations in Sacramento continue amid increasing pressure to do more on housing, that leaves people like Jackson to wade through today's patchwork reality.

She still hopes to move closer to her niece in Santa Clara, or her sister in Hollister. But with mundane tasks like figuring out how to transfer her voucher between counties once again turning into a Herculean effort, it's hard not to remember the last time she fell through the cracks.

"It's like they don't want to talk to each other," Jackson said. "I mean, it's crazy."

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